

Please check the examination details below before entering your candidate information

CANDIDATE SURNAME

OTHER NAMES

CENTRE NUMBER

CANDIDATE NUMBER

Pearson Edexcel GCSE (9–1)

HISTORY · PAPER 3: MODERN DEPTH STUDY

Time: 1 hour 20 minutes (Complete Mock) · 52 Marks (+4 SPaG)

Option 33: Conflict at Home and Abroad: the USA, 1954–75

Key Topic 3: US Involvement in the Vietnam War, 1954–68

Comprehensive 11-Page Specification Practice Pack · 1954–1968

PAPER
REFERENCE

1H10/33

Instructions: Use black ink or ball-point pen. Fill in candidate details above.

- Answer ALL questions in Section A (Question 1 and Question 2).
- Answer ALL questions in Section B (Question 3(a), 3(b), 3(c), and 3(d)).
- Read the Section B Historical Enquiry Dossier carefully on Page 5 before attempting Questions 3(a)–(d).

TOTAL MARKS

56

(52 + 4 SPaG)

Advice: Spend approx. 15 minutes on Section A Q1–Q2, and 60 minutes on Section B Q3(a)–(d). **SPaG:** 4 marks are awarded for spelling, punctuation, grammar, and specialist terms on Q3(d).

Q	TYPE	SPECIFICATION TOPIC FOCUS	PAGE	MARKS	AUDIT
SECTION A: TIMED EXAM PAPER (COMPULSORY QUESTION 1 & QUESTION 2)					
Q1	INFERENCE	Source A: Ineffectiveness of US Aerial Bombing (Sheehan Report)	P2	[4]	☐ / 4
Q2	EXPLAIN WHY	Escalation of US Involvement under LBJ (1964–65)	P3	[12]	☐ / 12
SECTION B: HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & INTERPRETATIONS (INTEGRATED 36M + 4 SPAG)					
Dossier	ENQUIRY	Dossier: Failure of US Military Tactics (Sources B, C & Ints 1, 2)	P4	Dossier	☐ / Read
3 (a)	UTILITY	Sources B & C: Failure of US Military Tactics in Vietnam	P5	[8]	☐ / 8
3 (b)	DIFFERENCE	Interpretations 1 & 2: Main Difference on Why Tactics Failed	P6	[4]	☐ / 4
3 (c)	REASON	Interpretations 1 & 2: Reasons for Difference in Historical Views	P6	[4]	☐ / 4
3 (d)	ESSAY	Evaluative Essay: How Far Do You Agree with Interpretation 1?	P7–8	[20]	☐ / 20
4	DEPTH BOOSTER	Spec Depth: How Vietcong Launched the Tet Offensive (1968)	P9	[12]	☐ / 12
SECTION C: GRADE 8/9 STANDARDS & EXAM TRAPS (SELF & PEER ASSESSMENT)					
Exemplars	SECTION A MODELS	Full Level 2 Model Q1 & Level 4 Model Q2 Essay + Examiner Marks	P10	Audit	☐ Verified
Exemplars	SECTION B MODELS	Full Level 3 Model Q3a, Q3b, Q3c & Level 4 Q3d Model + Top 3 Traps	P11	Audit	☐ Verified

Source A: A US Soldier on Combat Patrol in the Swamps of South Vietnam, 1966

US National Archives • Records of the Office of the Chief of Military History, Vietnam Collection



An American soldier from the 9th Infantry Division wades through chest-deep swamp water carrying an M60 machine gun and bandoliers of ammunition during a search-and-destroy mission against Vietcong guerrillas in the Mekong Delta.

Provenance: Official combat photograph taken by US Army military photographers in South Vietnam, 1966 (National Archives Record Group 111).

1 Give two things you can infer from Source A about the conditions faced by US infantry patrols fighting in South Vietnam (1965–68). (4)

(I) INFERENCE 1:

What I can infer from Source A:

.....

Details in the source that tell me this:

.....

(II) INFERENCE 2:

What I can infer from Source A:

.....

Details in the source that tell me this:

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Candidate Response Lines:

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Spend approx. 15 minutes on Question 2. Construct three developed causal paragraphs.

2 Explain why US involvement in Vietnam escalated under President Johnson between 1964 and 1965. (12)

(You must also use information of your own.)

A decisive turning point occurred when... In response, Congress...

This escalation was accelerated by... Consequently, ...

This directly resulted in...

Paragraph 3 Focus (Compulsory Own Knowledge): Paragraph 3: Troop Deployments & Da Nang (Own Knowledge) — Landing of 3,500 Marines in March 1965 to defend air bases, beginning full ground combat commitment.

☐ 3 Developed Causal Factors ☐ Beyond Stimulus Own Fact ☐ Explicit Connectives ☐ Sustained Analytical Focus

SECTION B: HISTORICAL ENQUIRY DOSSIER

Read this archival dossier carefully. All questions in Section B (Questions 3a–3d) relate to these materials.

SECTION B DOSSIER

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY FOCUS: THE REASONS WHY US MILITARY TACTICS FAILED TO DEFEAT THE VIETCONG (1965–68) PAPER 3 · SECTION B

Source B: From combat memoirs by US Marine Lieutenant Philip Caputo, published in ‘A Rumor of War’ (1977)

Marine Corps Historical Center

"We were sent on ‘search and destroy’ patrols through dense jungle and steaming swamps. The strategy was simple: find the enemy, fix him, and destroy him with massive artillery and air strikes. But we could almost never locate him. The Vietcong fought on their own terms: a sudden burst of fire from concealed tree lines, a sniper round, or an explosive booby trap made from a recycled artillery shell and bamboo punji sticks. When we entered a village, we could not distinguish a friendly farmer by day from a guerrilla fighter by night. Frustrated soldiers burned thatched huts with Zippo lighters, turning the very peasants we were sent to defend into sworn enemies."

Provenance: Written by Philip Caputo, a US Marine lieutenant who commanded combat infantry units in South Vietnam in 1965–66.

Source C: From an interview with Vo Thi Mo, a female Vietcong guerrilla fighter in Cu Chi district, recorded in 1982

War Remnants Museum

"The Americans possessed immense firepower—jets, helicopters, tanks, and chemical poisons that destroyed our rice crops. But they did not know the forest, and they did not know our people. Beneath the soil, we built over two hundred kilometers of multi-level tunnels with barracks, hospitals, and weapons factories. When their planes bombed, we remained safe twenty feet underground. When their infantry advanced, our booby traps—punji stakes smeared with animal dung, tripwires, and toe-poppers—inflicted daily casualties and wrecked their nerves. We were fighting for our own homeland; their soldiers fought only because they were drafted."

Provenance: Oral history interview with a veteran Vietcong combatant who operated in the Cu Chi tunnel network throughout the war.

Interpretation 1

HISTORIOGRAPHY

From Historian Christian G. Appy, 'Working-Class War: American Combat Soldiers and Vietnam' (1993):

"American military tactics were fundamentally mismatched with the political realities of guerrilla warfare in Vietnam. General Westmoreland's strategy of ‘search and destroy’ relied on attrition—measuring progress through enemy ‘body counts’ rather than securing territory. Because US troops were dropped into hostile territory by helicopter and evacuated immediately after contact, they never established permanent security for South Vietnamese villagers. Furthermore, the massive reliance on indiscriminate firepower—napalm, defoliants (Agent Orange), and artillery—inflicted horrific civilian casualties, alienating the rural population and pushing thousands of previously neutral peasants into active support for the National Liberation Front."

Interpretation 2

HISTORIOGRAPHY

From Historian Guenter Lewy, 'America in Vietnam' (1978):

"The failure of the American military effort was not primarily due to flawed US tactics, but to the extraordinary effectiveness, discipline, and strategic design of the communist insurgency. The Vietcong and North Vietnamese Army operated an exceptionally sophisticated underground logistics infrastructure. Their vast network of subterranean tunnels in Cu Chi and the Iron Triangle neutralized American air superiority. Moreover, the Vietcong enforced strict discipline, utilized terror ruthlessly to eliminate uncooperative village leaders, and benefited from an inexhaustible flow of Soviet and Chinese weapons down the Ho Chi Minh Trail. The tenacity and survival techniques of the communist cadres made them impervious to military defeat."

Enquiry Core: Source B & C provide contemporary primary evidence; Interpretations 1 & 2 provide competing modern historical views. Keep Page 5 open for Q3(a)–(d)

Spend approx. 12 minutes on Question 3(a). Evaluate content, provenance (COP), and context.

3 (a) Study Sources B and C. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the reasons why US military tactics failed to defeat the Vietcong (1965–68)? (8)

Contextual Knowledge: Explain Search and Destroy, Operation Rolling Thunder, Agent Orange, punji traps, Cu Chi tunnels, and the Ho Chi Minh Trail.

SECTION B: TIMED EXAM PAPER · QUESTION 3(B) & 3(C)

Spend approx. 5 minutes on Q3(b) and 5 minutes on Q3(c). Write in concise, focused prose.

Q3(B) & Q3(C): INTERPRETATIONS [8M]

3 (b) Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about why US military tactics failed to defeat the Vietcong. What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations. (4)

Direct Contrast Frame: Interpretation 1 argues that... whereas Interpretation 2 argues that...

3 (c) Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about why US military tactics failed to defeat the Vietcong. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4)

Different Views Frame: The historians give different views because they have relied on different sources/evidence. Interpretation 1 is supported by Source B, which emphasizes... whereas Interpretation 2 is supported by Source C, which emphasizes...

Spend approx. 25 minutes on Question 3(d). 16 marks for content + 4 marks for SPaG.

3 (d) How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about the reasons why US military tactics failed to defeat the Vietcong (1965–68)? (16 + 4 SPaG)

- Points in Int 2 that are valid
- Evidence from Source C supporting this
- Specific contextual knowledge backing it

- Counter-argument in Int 1
- Evidence from Source B supporting this
- Specific contextual knowledge backing it

- Flawed US military tactics (Search and Destroy, body counts, Zippo raids, napalm/Agent Orange destroying villages)
- Guerrilla tactics & terrain advantages (Cu Chi tunnels, booby traps, lack of uniform, peasant concealment)
- External communist support (Ho Chi Minh Trail, Soviet and Chinese modern weapons, anti-aircraft guns)

SECTION B: TIMED EXAM PAPER • QUESTION 3(D) (CONTINUED)

Complete your synthesis and reach a weighed, criteria-based conclusion.

Q3(D): CONCLUSION & JUDGEMENT

Conclusion Rule: State explicitly *how far* you agree with Interpretation 2 using your chosen criteria. Do not merely summarize.

SPaG Check: Capital letters for proper nouns (e.g. SCLC, Supreme Court, Vietcong).

Lined area for writing the conclusion and judgement.

PEARSON EDEXCEL LEVEL 4 MARK SCHEME [13–16 MARKS + 4 SPAG = 17–20 MARKS]:

☐ Both Interpretations Weighed ☐ Extensive Contextual Facts ☐ Sustained Evaluative Criteria ☐ Flawless SPaG & Specialist Terms

Exhaustive specification coverage. Practice an alternative high-yield exam question for this Key Topic.

4 Explain why the Vietcong and North Vietnamese Army were able to launch the Tet Offensive in January 1968. (12)

(You must also use information of your own.)

Tet Lunar New Year holiday	31 January 1968 assault	84,000 communist troops
Attacks on 100+ cities & Saigon US Embassy		
Khe Sanh diversion drew US forces away		
Smuggled arms in coffins & vegetable carts		

- **P1:** Logistics & Supply Lines: The Ho Chi Minh Trail moving Soviet and Chinese heavy weapons and 84,000 troops south undetected.
- **P2:** Strategic Diversion at Khe Sanh: General Giap attacking the remote Marine base at Khe Sanh to lure US reserves away from major cities.
- **P3:** Tactical Surprise & Infiltration (Own Knowledge): Breaking the traditional holiday truce and smuggling weapons into Saigon in false-bottomed trucks.

SECTION C: HIGH-SCORING EXEMPLAR RESPONSES • SECTION A

Official Pearson Edexcel Level 2 & Level 4 continuous prose models with examiner annotations.

GRADE 8/9 MODELS: Q1 & Q2

QUESTION 1: SOURCE INFERENCE EXEMPLAR

FULL MARKS • LEVEL 2 (4/4)

Give two things you can infer from Source A about the conditions faced by US infantry patrols fighting in South Vietnam (1965–68).

(i) What I can infer: I can infer that American ground troops had to operate in treacherous, exhausting physical conditions in the Vietnamese countryside. Details in the source that tell me this: The soldier is shown wading through deep, muddy swamp water and dense vegetation that severely hindered mobility.

(ii) What I can infer: I can infer that infantrymen were forced to carry immense physical loads of heavy weaponry to prepare for surprise ambushes. Details in the source that tell me this: The soldier is carrying a heavy M60 machine gun and long belts of live ammunition draped over his shoulder while traversing the swamp.

Examiner Annotation: Level 2 (4/4 Marks): Two valid inferences supported by specific visual details from the combat photograph.

QUESTION 2: CAUSATION ESSAY EXEMPLAR

FULL MARKS • LEVEL 4 (12/12)

Explain why US involvement in Vietnam escalated under President Johnson between 1964 and 1965. (12 marks)

A major reason for the escalation of US involvement was the Gulf of Tonkin incident in August 1964. Following alleged North Vietnamese torpedo boat attacks against the destroyer USS Maddox in international waters, President Lyndon B. Johnson requested emergency powers from Congress. The resulting Gulf of Tonkin Resolution passed almost unanimously, granting Johnson the constitutional authority to "take all necessary measures to repel any armed attack against the forces of the United States." This effectively served as a functional declaration of war and a blank check, enabling the president to escalate military commitments without formal congressional debate.

Furthermore, escalation was triggered by the Vietcong attack on the American airbase at Pleiku in February 1965. A surprise mortar attack killed eight American servicemen and wounded over one hundred, destroying ten aircraft. Johnson felt compelled to respond decisively to prove American resolve and deter communist aggression, declaring that he would not let Saigon fall. Within days, Johnson authorized Operation Rolling Thunder—a sustained, multi-year aerial bombardment campaign targeting North Vietnamese military bases, supply routes, and rail lines across the 17th parallel.

Finally, the escalation to ground combat troops was driven by the catastrophic military weakness of the South Vietnamese Army (ARVN) and the immediate necessity to protect US air bases. General William Westmoreland warned Washington that the corrupt Saigon regime was on the verge of total military collapse. In March 1965, Johnson deployed 3,500 US Marines to land on the beaches of Da Nang to guard the American airfield. Once ground combat troops were committed to defensive duties, Westmoreland rapidly shifted their mission to aggressive 'search and destroy' patrols, causing US troop numbers to skyrocket to over 184,000 by the end of 1965.

Examiner Annotation: Level 4 (12/12 Marks): Comprehensive 3-part causal analysis; covers the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution, Pleiku/Rolling Thunder, and the Da Nang troop landings; clear analytical flow and strong factual support.

SECTION C: SECTION B MODELS & FATAL EXAMINER TRAPS

Official Level 3 & Level 4 continuous prose models and high-frequency pitfalls to avoid.

GRADE 8/9 MODELS: Q3 & TRAPS

QUESTION 3(A): SOURCE UTILITY EXEMPLAR

FULL MARKS · LEVEL 3 (8/8)

Source B is exceptionally useful because it provides an unvarnished firsthand account from an American combat officer detailing the fundamental operational flaws of search-and-destroy tactics. Lieutenant Philip Caputo reveals that despite massive air and artillery firepower, US troops could rarely locate the elusive guerrilla enemy, who dictated the terms of combat through sudden ambushes and homemade booby traps. Furthermore, Caputo highlights how the inability to distinguish guerrillas from innocent peasants led soldiers to burn thatched huts ("Zippo raids"), thereby alienating the very population the US intended to protect. The provenance gives it great value: written by a frontline combat officer with no reason to flatter high command, it offers authentic insight into soldier demoralization.

Source C is equally useful because it offers an invaluable primary perspective from the opposing side, explaining the subterranean tactics that neutralized American technological superiority. Vo Thi Mo describes how the Cu Chi tunnel network—stretching over 200 kilometers across multiple levels—enabled Vietcong fighters to survive heavy aerial bombardment, manufacture weapons, and live safely underground. Furthermore, she highlights the psychological power of low-tech booby traps (punji stakes) in wrecking American morale and emphasizes the deep motivation of fighting for one's homeland compared to conscripted US troops. Evaluated in the context of the Ho Chi Minh Trail and General Westmoreland's failed strategy of attrition, both sources are immensely useful: Source B exposes the tactical frustration and alienation caused by American search-and-destroy methods, while Source C demonstrates the extraordinary resilience and tactical ingenuity of the communist underground resistance.

Examiner Annotation: Level 3 (8/8 Marks): Perceptive evaluation of both sources; examines tactical failure vs guerrilla resilience; integrates provenance (nature, origin, purpose) and detailed contextual knowledge.

QUESTION 3(B) & 3(C): INTERPRETATIONS EXEMPLAR

FULL MARKS · LEVEL 2 (4/4 + 4/4)

Q3(b) Difference: The main difference is that Interpretation 1 attributes US failure to flawed American military strategies—specifically search-and-destroy, body counts, and the excessive use of firepower (napalm, Agent Orange) that turned the peasant population against the US. On the other hand, Interpretation 2 argues that failure was primarily caused by the extraordinary resilience, discipline, and subterranean tunnel engineering of the Vietcong, supported by Chinese and Soviet arms supplies down the Ho Chi Minh Trail.

Q3(c) Reason: Interpretations 1 and 2 differ because the historians have investigated different dimensions of the war. The author of Interpretation 1 has focused on American military command records and veteran testimonies like Source B, analyzing the failure of search-and-destroy tactics and the moral alienation of the Vietnamese peasantry. In contrast, the author of Interpretation 2 has focused on Vietnamese guerrilla engineering and communist military archives like Source C, evaluating the military effectiveness of the Cu Chi tunnel systems and the logistical resilience of the National Liberation Front.

Examiner Annotation: Q3b: Level 2 (4/4 Marks): Direct, clear contrast of main viewpoints supported by specific details and terminology from both texts. | Q3c: Level 2 (4/4 Marks): Sound historical explanation linking differing interpretations to differing source materials and historical focuses.

QUESTION 3(D): EVALUATIVE ESSAY CONCLUSION MODEL

FULL MARKS · LEVEL 4 (16+4 = 20/20)

In conclusion, I agree with Interpretation 2 to a very large extent, because the remarkable tactical resilience, discipline, and subterranean ingenuity of the Vietcong were the decisive factors that neutralized America's overwhelming technological superiority. As detailed in Source C, the construction of over 200 kilometers of multi-tiered tunnels at Cu Chi enabled guerrilla fighters to survive intense aerial bombing, conceal weapons workshops, and emerge behind US patrols to launch lethal ambushes. Coupled with low-tech booby traps (punji stakes) that inflicted heavy psychological casualties, and the constant influx of supplies down the Ho Chi Minh Trail, the communists dictated the geography and tempo of combat. However, Interpretation 2 must be evaluated alongside the fatal operational flaws of American strategy outlined in Interpretation 1. As revealed in Source B, General Westmoreland's reliance on conventional 'search and destroy' missions, measured purely by body counts, alienated the civilian peasantry whose allegiance was essential for counter-insurgency victory. Indiscriminate saturation bombing, napalm, and Agent Orange defoliation destroyed ancestral villages and turned ordinary farmers into active Vietcong sympathizers. Therefore, while American tactical blunders created immense popular hostility, it was the Vietcong's superior guerrilla resilience and tunnel infrastructure that ultimately made them impossible to defeat.

Examiner Annotation: Level 4 (16+4 = 20/20 Marks): Nuanced, criteria-based evaluation; compares flawed US firepower against Vietcong tactical adaptability; demonstrates mastery of historical context.

TOP 3 FATAL EXAMINER TRAPS TO AVOID FOR KEY TOPIC 3

- **Vietcong were NOT the North Vietnamese Army**
The Vietcong (National Liberation Front) were South Vietnamese communist guerrillas fighting in the south. The NVA (PAVN) were the regular army of communist North Vietnam.
- **Agent Orange was a DEFOLIANT, not a poison gas**
Agent Orange was a chemical herbicide designed to strip jungle foliage and expose guerrilla trails. Napalm was a sticky jellied petroleum incendiary bomb. Do not confuse them.
- **Search and Destroy measured SUCCESS BY BODY COUNT**
Unlike WWII, territory was not captured and held. US troops landed by helicopter, fought, counted dead enemy bodies, and evacuated, allowing the Vietcong to re-occupy the area immediately.